# BJP UPS THE ANTE

**THE BOOTH COMMITTEES ARE STRONGER, THERE IS LESS FACTIONALISM, AND BELIEF IN THE PARTY ORGANISATION IS HIGH. WILL IT BE ENOUGH FOR THE BJP TO BREACH THE TMC CITADEL OF WEST BENGAL?**

By **ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR**



AFP

**On April 2, Amit Shah was at a rally in Bhabanipur where he struck a markedly measured tone. Gone was the fire and brimstone of 2021, when the Union home minister and BJP No. 2 had predicted over 200 seats for the party (in the 294-member assembly). This time, seeking support for leader of the Opposition and party candidate here, Suvendu Adhikari, Shah scaled the target down to "at least 170 seats".**

Still, even if the rhetoric appeared tempered, there was no doubting the confidence behind it. The BJP in Bengal, long criticised for its fragile organisation, believes it has rebuilt itself from booth up. Adhikari's second nomination from Bhabanipur (he's also contesting from Nandigram), where he's taking on chief minister and Trinamool Congress (TMC) chairperson Mamata Banerjee in her backyard, was obviously meant to signal this aggressive political push.

For years, the BJP began with a disadvantage in Bengal. Roughly 30 per cent of the electorate comprises Muslims, a demographic that has consolidated behind the TMC. This effectively meant the BJP started many of the contests one step behind. But its deeper weaknesses lay elsewhere. Even in Hindu-dominated regions, the party often lacked booth-level strength. The 2021 assembly election aftermath, especially the post-poll violence, exposed this fragility. The leaders who had parachuted in from other states had left soon after the polls, and the local leadership was inaccessible. Many BJP grassroots workers felt abandoned; the psychological impact was severe. Morale dipped. Networks collapsed. Yet, paradoxically, the party's vote base did not entirely erode. In the 2023 panchayat elections, despite widespread allegations of violence again, the BJP won over 9,700 gram panchayat seats (over 15 per cent of the total 63,000-plus seats). It signalled something important—a segment of the electorate continued to back the BJP.

## The Bansal Blueprint

**The man tasked with the state unit overhaul was party general secretary** Sunil Bansal, who had been appointed central observer for Bengal in August 2022. His predecessor, Madhya Pradesh leader Kailash Vijayvargiya, had been a controversial figure. The latter's strategy of inducting TMC defectors and giving them tickets got much flak within the party, and he even took a hit for the organisational disarray and the 2021 loss.

Bansal's approach was different. For months, he travelled across Bengal, holding meetings, understanding factional dynamics and mapping organisational gaps. The real push, however, came after the 2024 Lok Sabha election. In October